

Guide for the Grown-Up

New here? This is everything you need. Read it once and you will be ready for any kit in the library. It takes about five minutes.

What this is

This is a cooperative story-and-puzzle adventure you play with a child, or a few children, out loud, with a printed kit and a few household bits. There is no app and no screen. You read a little story, the children make choices, and together you solve gentle puzzles with simple dice. You are all on the same side, helping each other through, never playing against one another. It is a way to practise imagination, problem-solving, and working together, and a lovely excuse for unhurried, screen-free time, which researchers link to how well children settle and thrive. You need no experience at all. If you can read a bedtime story, you can run this.

Your jobs, and you get to play too

You are the **Game Master**, which is just a few small jobs at once. You are also a fellow adventurer at the table, not a referee standing apart: you play on the children's side, helping them find the way.

- **The narrator.** Read the story parts aloud, warmly. Do a silly voice if you fancy it. Pause at the questions and let the children answer.
- **The gentle referee.** When the players try something, you decide how it goes, always leaning towards yes. The puzzle pages give you the answers, so you are never caught out.
- **The biggest fan.** Cheer every idea, especially the odd ones. Your delight is the engine of the whole game.
- **A fellow adventurer.** Take a hero of your own and play along. You have read ahead, but you do not have to act like it: let yourself be surprised, wonder out loud, and discover each turn with the children. Helping them through is the whole point, not being the one who knows.

The one golden rule: yes, and

Whatever your child suggests, try to say "**yes, and...**" rather than "no". If they want to befriend the monster, talk to the river, or fly on a borrowed cloud, let them, and add a little twist that keeps the story moving. "Yes, the vines pull back, and as they do you spot something glinting underneath." Saying yes keeps a child leaning in. Saying no, again and again, is the one sure way to lose them.

Nobody loses, ever

This is the heart of every kit: **a failed roll is never a defeat, only a detour.** If a dice roll comes up short, do not stop the story. The players can spend an energy star and try again, combine their strengths, accept a helpful nudge from a friendly creature, or simply find another way round. Treat a miss as a funny surprise, not a failure. No child is ever knocked out, left behind, or made to feel they have let the team down.

When they get stuck

Sticking is normal. Reach for these, in order:

- Offer a **friendly hint** through a character ("the cat nudges a loose vine...").

- **Lower the difficulty** one band, or let the helper roll carry it.
- Let them **combine their strengths** for an automatic success.
- If all else stalls, **just let them succeed**. Momentum matters more than rigour. A child who feels clever will play for an hour; a child who feels stuck will wander off.

Keeping a young child captivated

- Do **voices** for the characters; it is half the magic.
- **Hand them the dice** and let them roll. Holding the dice is holding the story.
- Offer **choices** ("do you knock, or do you peek?") rather than open silence.
- Keep scenes **short** and end on a small win.
- **Follow their excitement**. If they love the talking fountain, linger there.
- **Take breaks**. A kit is happy to be played across several sittings.

Silly or impossible answers

These are a gift, not a problem. If your child says the door opens because "a dragon eats it", grin and run with it: "the dragon gulps the gate down, burps, and trots off, and now the way is clear." If an idea truly cannot work, let the world answer kindly: "the rock is too heavy to lift, but look, there is a gap you could wriggle through." Never just block them; always offer a door.

Pacing and length

Aim for fifteen to thirty minutes at a sitting, less for little ones. You may **skip a puzzle**, shorten the reading, or **stop early** and pick up next time. There is no clock and no score. The best ending is a child asking to play again.

A handful of ready phrases

Keep these on the tip of your tongue:

- "Yes, and..."
- "Ooh, what a clever idea. What happens next?"
- "You can absolutely try that. Let us see..."
- "That did not quite work, so what else could we do?"
- "You did that by being clever and kind. Well done."

Wits and Wonder

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<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.